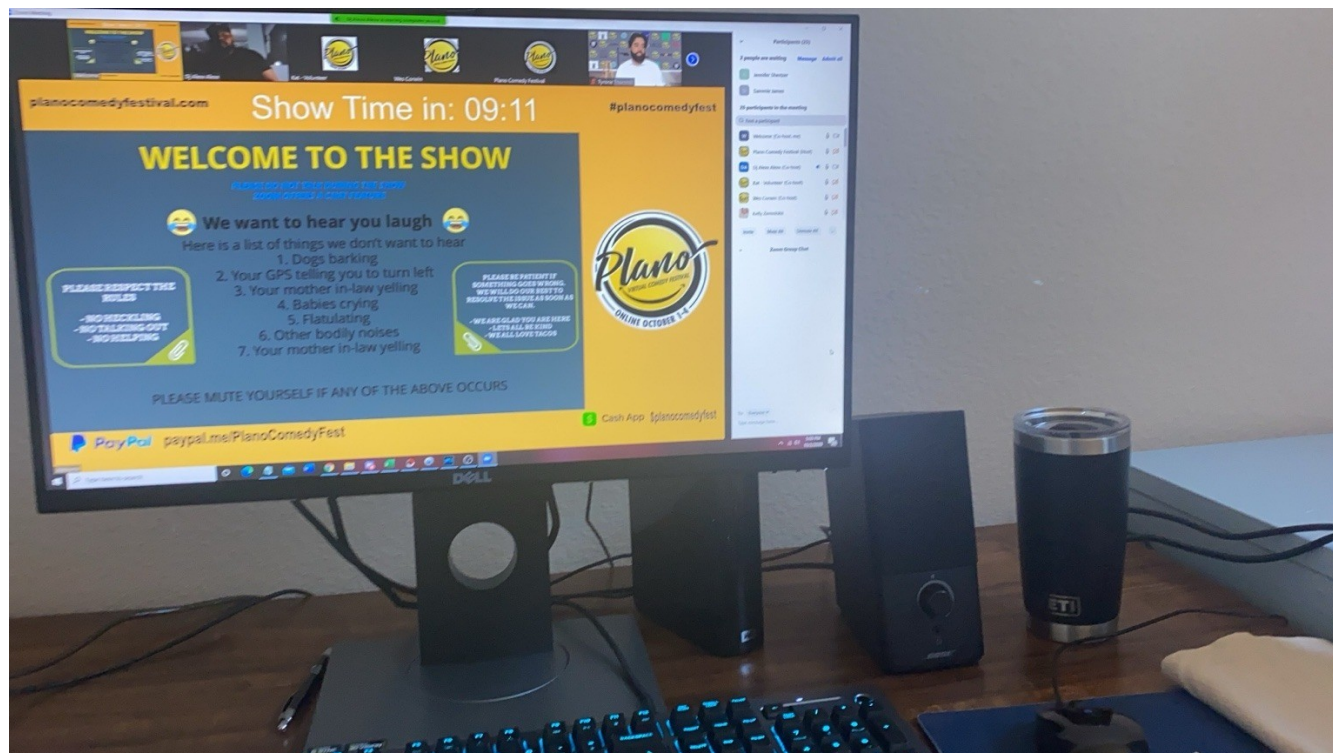


PLANO VIRTUAL COMEDY FESTIVAL

Rebuilding a live comedy festival for a fully remote world



Behind the scenes of the virtual production environment.

100+

PERFORMERS

21

STATES

4

COUNTRIES

17

SHOWS

4

DAYS

THOMAS SMITH

Co-Producer | Event Operations | Virtual Production | Marketing & QA

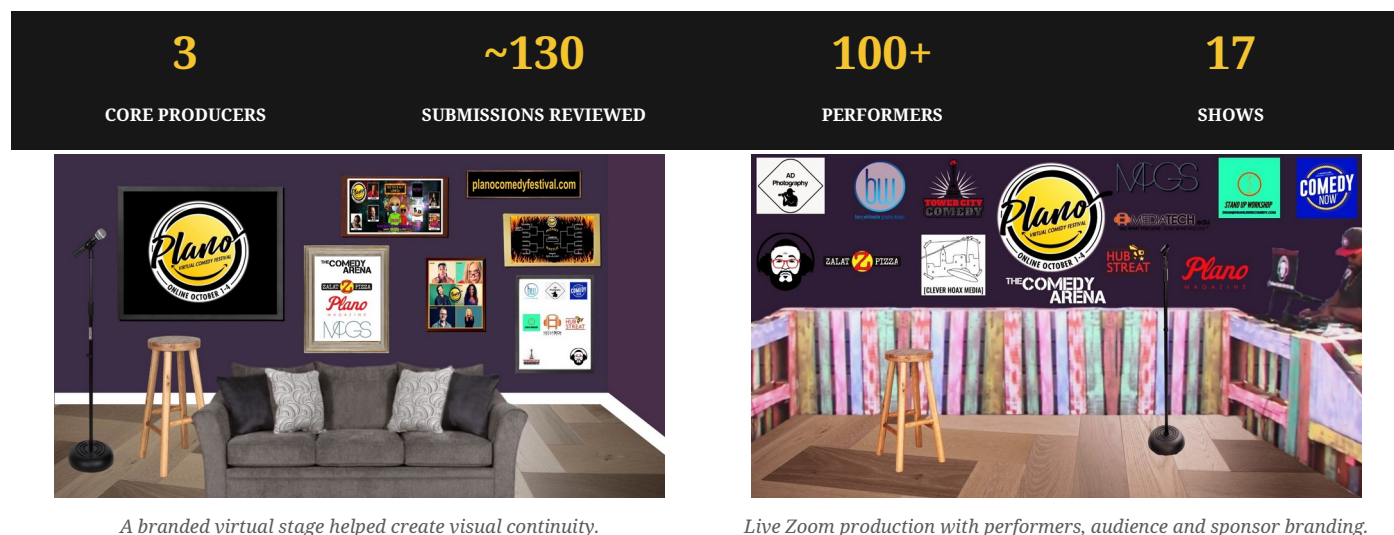
October 1-4, 2020

THE ASSIGNMENT

Turn a physical festival into an experience people could attend from home

When COVID-19 made a traditional in-person festival impossible, the Plano Comedy Festival moved its third annual event online. Contemporary coverage documented more than 100 performers from 21 states and four countries, with 17 shows over four days.

The challenge was larger than opening a Zoom meeting. The team had to preserve the feeling of a multi-day festival while performers, volunteers, producers and attendees were geographically separated.



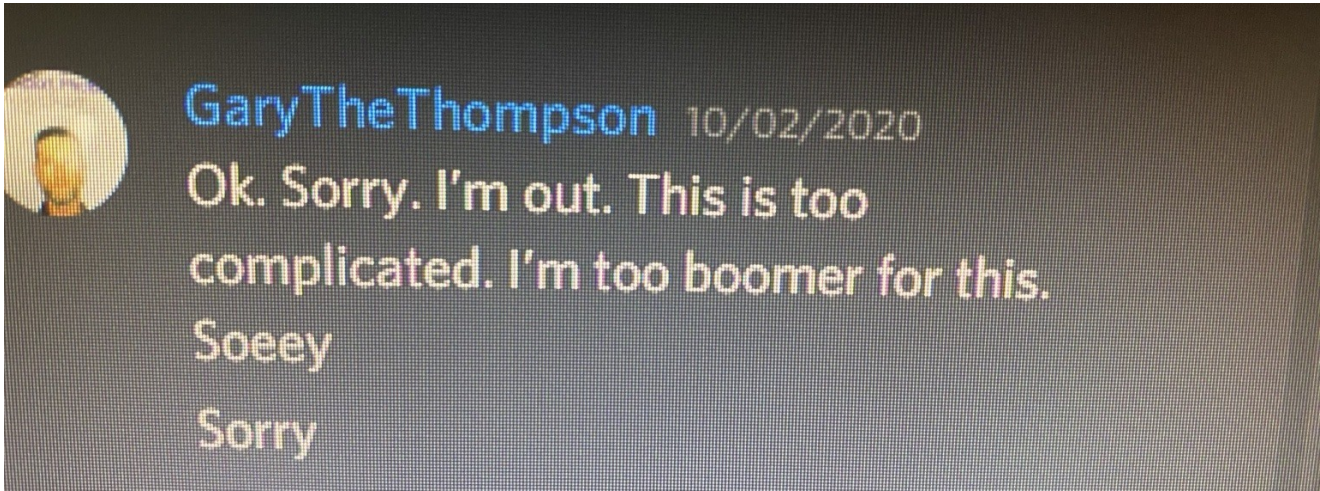
My role

As part of the three-person core production team, I worked across operations, marketing, QA and live production. The project required switching constantly between creative, technical and logistical responsibilities.

- Reviewed performer submissions and helped build programming and schedules
- Created/reviewed promotional graphics, badges and social content
- Learned and implemented OBS workflows for live transitions
- Helped design the virtual attendee experience and audience instructions
- Coordinated performers, volunteers, show logistics and digital materials
- Applied QA practices to website content, schedules and performer information
- Supported Zoom spotlighting, show transitions and troubleshooting
- Served as a live ring announcer for the Roast Battle

The audience journey began before the first joke

Comedy depends on audience response. Muting everyone would remove an essential part of the performance, but open microphones could also introduce dogs, conversations and household noise. The team created pre-show audience education explaining how to participate in a virtual comedy performance.



Pre-show audience education included a countdown, participation guidance, branding and sponsor visibility.

The resulting attendee journey was intentional rather than accidental:

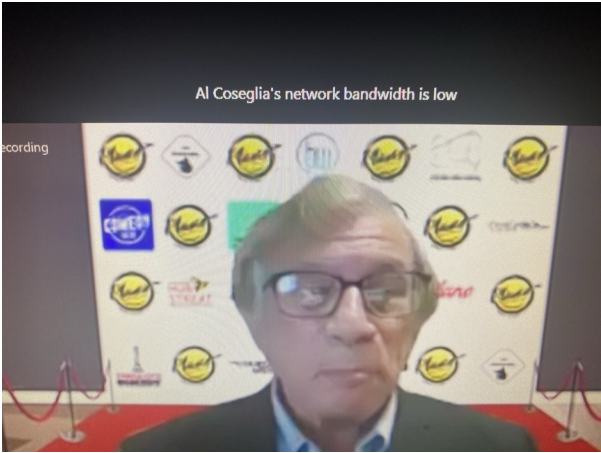
TICKET	ARRIVAL	PRE-SHOW	ORIENTATION	LIVE SHOW	AFTER-PARTY
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A virtual venue, not just a video call

Branded virtual backgrounds gave performers in different homes and locations a shared visual environment. Sponsor logos, festival branding and stage imagery created continuity from show to show.



Live performer on the branded virtual stage.



Remote production setup during the festival.

Building the production workflow while learning it

The festival combined Zoom, OBS, Eventbrite, Discord, Powtoon, social media and custom digital graphics. OBS supported transitions between pre-show material and live programming; Zoom became the performance venue; Discord provided a virtual green room; Eventbrite supported ticketing.

ZOOM	OBS	DISCORD	EVENTBRITE
VENUE	PRODUCTION	GREEN ROOM	TICKETING

This was live event work: bandwidth problems, varying levels of participant technical comfort, incorrect assets and other issues had to be handled without stopping a four-day program. The first show was not successfully recorded, and the team adjusted the workflow for subsequent shows.



A home production station running the festival's virtual workflow.

QA became an event-production advantage

My software QA background translated naturally to virtual event operations: checking website and digital content, verifying performer information, catching incorrect assets, testing workflows and confirming fixes before execution.

TEST → IDENTIFY → CORRECT → VERIFY → EXECUTE

PROGRAMMING

The goal was to preserve the variety of a real festival

The 2020 program went beyond traditional stand-up. Public coverage documented stand-up alongside improv, sketch, musical and alternative comedy, a comedy brunch, workshops, a free family show, a Roast Battle and nightly after-parties with games, karaoke and prizes.



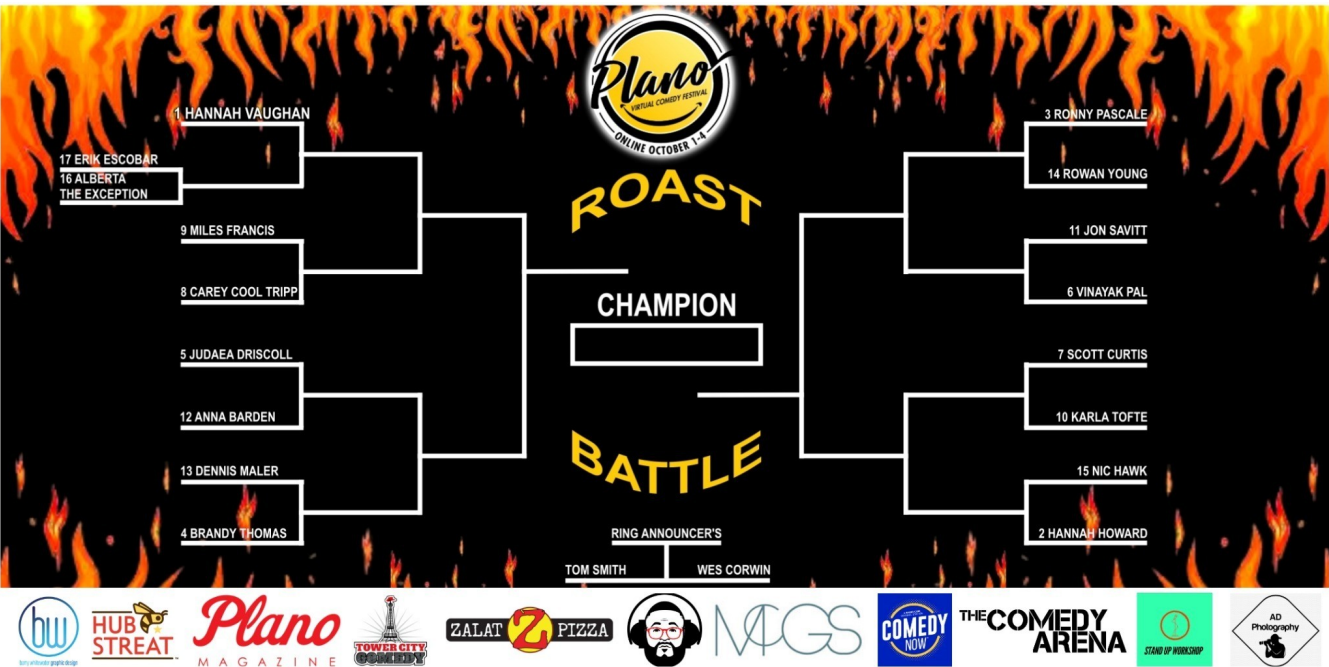
Specialized programming received its own promotional identity.



Festival programming was marketed as individual experiences.

The Roast Battle

The Sunday-night Roast Battle was built as a 16-performer tournament with dedicated fight-style branding, individual promotional cards and a full bracket. Wes Corwin and I served as ring announcers, adding an audience-facing performance role to our production responsibilities.



The 16-performer Roast Battle bracket, including sponsor integration and ring announcers Tom Smith and Wes Corwin.



Tom Smith - Ring Announcer



Wes Corwin - Ring Announcer

A festival needed a complete digital identity

The virtual event required a large volume of coordinated digital material: performer promotional cards, show posters, virtual badges, headliner graphics, sponsor placements, pre-show slides, social content and promotional video.



Performer badge / promotional asset.



Show-specific promotional graphic.

Performers also amplified the festival through their own social channels, extending reach beyond the festival's accounts. The event's digital assets therefore supported both operations and marketing.

Contemporaneous feedback

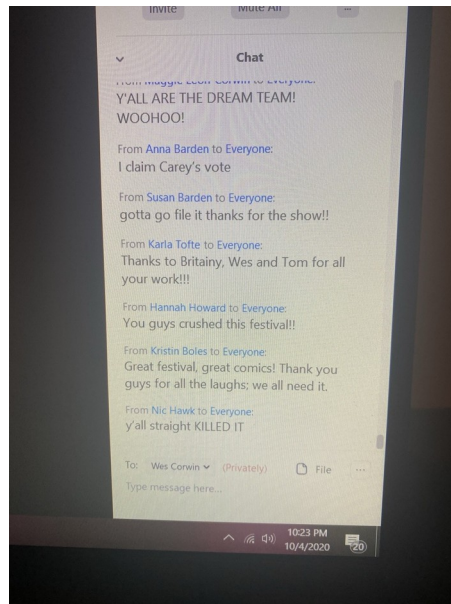
Surviving Zoom screenshots captured participant and audience reactions during the festival itself:

"Thanks to Britiany, Wes and Tom for all your work!!!"

"You guys crushed this festival!!!"

"Great festival, great comics! Thank you guys for all the laughs; we all need it."

"y'all straight KILLED IT"



Participant and audience feedback captured in the live Zoom chat.

OUTCOME

What this project demonstrates

The festival delivered a complex, multi-day virtual event during a period when the live-event industry was rapidly reinventing itself. The work demonstrates the ability to learn unfamiliar technology quickly, coordinate distributed stakeholders and keep a live program moving when plans meet reality.

- Remote event production and live operations
- Performer, volunteer and stakeholder communication
- Live troubleshooting under time pressure
- Digital marketing and promotional asset coordination
- Sponsor integration
- Program and schedule coordination
- Attendee experience design
- Rapid adoption of unfamiliar technology
- Website and content quality assurance
- Cross-functional collaboration in a small team

THE CORE RESULT

We did not simply move a festival onto Zoom. We redesigned the experience for a remote audience and delivered it live.

Public validation

Independent 2020 coverage documented the festival's virtual transition, dates, scale, programming and headliners. The current Plano Comedy Festival alumni archive also preserves the 2020 performer roster.

Plano Magazine - Plano Comedy Fest Announces 2020 Headliners — planomagazine.com/plano-comedy-fest-2020/

The Dallas Morning News - Need a laugh? Plano's virtual comedy festival is coming soon — dallasnews.com/arts-entertainment/things-to-do/2020/09/16/need-a-laugh-planos-virtual-comedy-festival-is-coming-soon/

CultureMap Dallas - Plano Virtual Comedy Festival — dallas.culturemap.com/eventdetail/plano-virtual-comedy-festival/

Dallas Observer - The Plano Comedy Festival Will Go Virtual Instead of Dark — dallasobserver.com/arts/the-plano-comedy-festival-will-go-virtual-instead-of-dark-11941761

Plano Comedy Festival - Festival Alumni — planocomedyfestival.com/festival-alumni

THOMAS SMITH | REMOTE EVENT OPERATIONS • VIRTUAL PRODUCTION • QA • PROGRAM COORDINATION